

Europe Trip 2025

Family Travel Plan

Travelers: 4 people (family group)
Duration: 21 days / 3 weeks
Dates: September 2025
Budget: \$10,000 USD total
Origin: Toronto, Ontario, Canada
Route: Toronto > Lisbon > Porto > Barcelona > Zurich > Toronto
Hotel Check-ins: 3 total (minimizing moves)
Flights: All direct - no layovers

"Slow travel focused on natural beauty, outdoor experiences, and family relaxation - avoiding tourist trap interiors and museum fatigue while maximizing coastal and alpine scenery with minimal logistical stress."

Trip Overview

Travel Preferences

- Nature-focused: beaches, mountains, hiking, coastal walks, waterfalls, viewpoints
- All direct flights only - no layovers, no connections
- Minimal hotel changes - base cities with day trips
- Maximum 1 major activity per day, relaxed pace
- Train travel for intercity and day trips
- Family-friendly accommodations with connecting rooms / family suites

What This Trip Does NOT Include

- ✗ No museums - zero museum visits
- ✗ No building interiors - no palaces, churches, or castles (exteriors OK)
- ✗ No layover flights - direct only
- ✗ No constant hotel hopping - 3 check-ins for 21 days

Route Summary

Week 1 - Portugal: Lisbon (5 nights) + Porto (2 nights) - Atlantic coast, cliffs, beaches

Week 2 - Spain: Barcelona (7 nights) - Mediterranean coast, mountains, beach towns

Week 3 - Switzerland: Zurich (6 nights) - Alpine waterfalls, lakes, mountain hiking

Flights (All Direct)

Route	Airlines	Duration	Per Person	Total (4)
Toronto > Lisbon	TAP / Air Canada / Transat	7h	\$450	\$1,800
Lisbon > Barcelona	TAP / Vueling / Ryanair	2h	\$50	\$200
Barcelona > Zurich	SWISS / Vueling	1h 45m	\$60	\$240
Zurich > Toronto	Air Canada / SWISS	9h	\$400	\$1,600
TOTAL				\$3,840

Booking Notes

- Book 2-3 months before September for best prices
- TAP Air Portugal: 8 nonstop flights/week Toronto-Lisbon
- Lisbon-Barcelona: 12+ direct flights daily (budget airlines available)
- Air Transat Toronto-Lisbon is seasonal - verify September availability

Accommodation (20 Nights, 3 Check-ins)

City	Hotel	Room Type	Nights	Rate	Total	Key Features
Lisbon	Hotel da Baixa ****	Family (Queen+King)	5	\$110	\$550	2-min to Rossio, breakfast
Porto	Moov Hotel ****	Superior (2dbl+sofa)	2	\$100	\$200	5-min to Sao Bento
Barcelona	Aparthotel Arai 4*S	Family apartment	7	\$120	\$840	Kitchenette, rooftop pool

City	Hotel	Room Type	Nights	Rate	Total	Key Features
Zurich	Hotel Glockenhof ****	Family Suite	6	\$160	\$960	Breakfast, Swiss chocolate
	TOTAL		20 nts		\$2,550	

Budget Breakdown (\$10,000 Total)

Category	Cost (4 ppl)	Notes
Flights	\$3,840	All direct: TAP, Air Canada, SWISS, Vueling
Accommodation	\$2,550	20 nights across 4 hotels (3 check-ins)
Swiss Travel Pass (8-day x4)	\$1,520	Unlimited Swiss trains/buses/boats + 50% mountain railways
Portugal trains/metro	\$140	Alfa Pendular Lisbon-Porto + local transit
Spain trains/metro	\$140	Barcelona day trips + T-Casual card
Activities	\$400	Cable cars, waterfall entries, boat rides
GRAND TOTAL	\$8,590	85.9% of budget allocated
REMAINING BUFFER	\$1,410	For food (~\$55/day avg), emergencies, extras

Food Budget Estimate (from buffer)

City	Days	Daily (4 ppl)	Total	Grocery Stores
Lisbon	5	\$45	\$225	Pingo Doce, Continente, Minipreco
Porto	2	\$45	\$90	Pingo Doce, Continente
Barcelona	7	\$55	\$385	Mercadona, Carrefour Express
Zurich	6	\$75	\$450	Migros (best), Coop, Aldi
TOTAL	20		\$1,150	Remaining after food: ~\$260

Week 1: Portugal (Days 1-7)

Base: Lisbon (5 nights) + Porto (2 nights) | Focus: Atlantic coast, cliffs, beaches

Day 1 - Arrive Lisbon

Time	Activity	Meal	Transport	Cost
Morning	In-flight from Toronto (7h direct)	Airline meal	TAP/Air Canada	\$0
Afternoon	Check into Hotel da Baixa, rest	Light lunch in Baixa	Metro from airport	\$15
Evening	Tagus River walk, sunset Praca do Comercio	Riverside dinner	Walking	\$20

Day 2 - Sintra Coast Day Trip

Time	Activity	Meal	Transport	Cost
Morning	Cabo da Roca - westernmost point of Europe	Hotel breakfast (incl.)	Train 40min	\$10
Afternoon	Hike to Praia da Ursa - wild beach, rocks	Packed lunch/cafe	Local bus	\$20
Evening	Praia do Guincho - dunes, surfing beach	Seafood dinner	Train back	\$10

Day 3 - Cascais & Portuguese Riviera

Time	Activity	Meal	Transport	Cost
Morning	Boca do Inferno sea cliffs	Hotel breakfast (incl.)	Train 40min	\$10
Afternoon	Praia da Duquesa beach, coastal cycling	Seafront restaurant	Walk/cycle	\$15
Evening	Sunset on Cascais promenade	Sunset seafood dinner	Train back	\$10

Day 4 - Arrabida Natural Park

Time	Activity	Meal	Transport	Cost
Morning	Mediterranean forest hike	Hotel breakfast (incl.)	Bus/taxi/rental	\$25
Afternoon	Praia de Galapinhos - crystal swimming	Packed lunch	Within park	\$10
Evening	Scenic drive back, relax	Dinner in Baixa	Return transport	\$15

Day 5 - Lisbon Miradouros & Tagus River

Time	Activity	Meal	Transport	Cost
Morning	Viewpoints: Senhora do Monte, Graca	Hotel breakfast (incl.)	Walking	\$0
Afternoon	Santa Luzia viewpoint, ferry to Cacilhas	Cafe lunch	Walk + ferry	\$10
Evening	Relaxed evening, pack for Porto	Farewell Lisbon dinner	Walking	\$5

Day 6 - Train to Porto + Douro River

Time	Activity	Meal	Transport	Cost
Morning	Alfa Pendular train (3h scenic ride)	Hotel breakfast (incl.)	Train	\$35
Afternoon	Check in Moov Hotel, Ribeira waterfront	Lunch overlooking Douro	Walking	\$0
Evening	Sunset Dom Luis I Bridge, Foz do Douro	Dinner in Foz do Douro	Walking	\$0

Day 7 - Porto Beaches & Nature

Time	Activity	Meal	Transport	Cost
Morning	Praia de Matosinhos - urban beach	Beachside cafe	Metro/bus	\$5
Afternoon	Walk Atlantic coast to Foz do Douro	Seaside restaurant	Coastal path	\$10
Evening	Palacio de Cristal gardens	Dinner historic center	Walking	\$10

Week 2: Spain (Days 8-15)

Base: Barcelona (7 nights) | Focus: Mediterranean coast, mountains, beach towns

Day 8 - Fly Porto to Barcelona

Time	Activity	Meal	Transport	Cost
Morning	Flight Porto-Barcelona (direct, 2h)	Hotel breakfast	Flight	\$60
Afternoon	Check into Aparthotel Arai, Gothic Qtr	Tapas in El Born	Aerobus	\$15
Evening	Stroll La Barceloneta beach	Tapas dinner El Born	Walking	\$0

Day 9 - Barceloneta & Waterfront

Time	Activity	Meal	Transport	Cost
Morning	Barceloneta Beach swimming	Kitchenette breakfast	Walking	\$5
Afternoon	Port Olimpic + Parc Ciutadella	Chiringuito lunch	Walking	\$10
Evening	Sunset W Hotel beach area	Waterfront dinner	Walking	\$10

Day 10 - Costa Brava: Tossa de Mar

Time	Activity	Meal	Transport	Cost
Morning	Train+bus to Tossa de Mar	Hotel breakfast	R1 train+bus	\$10
Afternoon	Platja Gran, ancient walls, cove hike	Old town lunch	Walking	\$10
Evening	Explore & return to Barcelona	Dinner	Bus+train	\$10

Day 11 - Montserrat Mountain

Time	Activity	Meal	Transport	Cost
Morning	FGC+rack railway to Montserrat	Hotel breakfast	FGC+rack	\$25
Afternoon	Sant Joan trail - panoramic views	Mountain restaurant	Hiking	\$10
Evening	Return to Barcelona	Dinner in Barcelona	Train back	\$0

Day 12 - Sitges Beach Town

Time	Activity	Meal	Transport	Cost
Morning	Train to Sitges beach town	Hotel breakfast	R2 train 35min	\$5
Afternoon	Platja de Sant Sebastia, promenade	Beachfront restaurant	Walking	\$10
Evening	Sunset beach drinks, return	Dinner	Train back	\$10

Day 13 - Girona & Costa Brava

Time	Activity	Meal	Transport	Cost
Morning	AVE to Girona, Onyar River walk	Hotel breakfast	AVE 40min	\$15
Afternoon	Calella de Palafrugell fishing village	Seaside restaurant	Bus	\$15
Evening	Return to Barcelona	Dinner in Barcelona	AVE train	\$10

Day 14 - Mount Tibidabo

Time	Activity	Meal	Transport	Cost
Morning	Metro+bus+funicular to summit (512m)	Hotel breakfast	Transit	\$15
Afternoon	Sky Walk panoramic, Collserola option	Mountain cafe	Walking	\$5
Evening	Return, rooftop pool at hotel	Gothic Quarter dinner	Transit	\$5

Day 15 - Beach Day + Travel to Switzerland

Time	Activity	Meal	Transport	Cost
Morning	Final beach at Barceloneta	Kitchenette breakfast	Walking	\$0
Afternoon	Flight Barcelona-Zurich (1h45m)	Airport lunch	Flight	\$60
Evening	Check in Glockenhof, Lake Zurich walk	Old Town dinner	Train 10min	\$0

Week 3: Switzerland (Days 16-21)

Base: Zurich (6 nights) | Focus: Alpine waterfalls, lakes, mountain hiking

SWISS TRAVEL PASS (8-Day) - \$380/person x 4 = \$1,520 | All trains/buses/boats FREE + 50% off mountain railways

Day 16 - Zurich Lake & Old Town

Time	Activity	Meal	Transport	Cost
Morning	Old Town walk, Lindenhof viewpoint	Hotel buffet (incl.)	Walking	\$0
Afternoon	Swim/relax Zurichhorn Park	Lakeside cafe	Walk/tram	\$10
Evening	Sunset boat cruise (FREE Swiss Pass)	Old Town dinner	Boat+walk	\$10

Day 17 - Lauterbrunnen Valley

Time	Activity	Meal	Transport	Cost
Morning	Train to Lauterbrunnen - 72 Waterfalls	Hotel buffet (incl.)	Rail FREE	\$0
Afternoon	Staubbach Falls + Trummelbach Falls	Village lunch	Walking	\$60
Evening	Alpine meadow walk, train back	Dinner in Zurich	Rail FREE	\$20

Day 18 - Grindelwald & First (2,168m)

Time	Activity	Meal	Transport	Cost
Morning	Train+cable car to First (50% off)	Hotel buffet (incl.)	Rail FREE+cable	\$100
Afternoon	Hike Lake Bachalpsee, First Cliff Walk	Packed/mountain lunch	Hiking	\$0
Evening	Cable car down, train back	Dinner in Zurich	Rail FREE	\$0

Day 19 - Lucerne & Lake

Time	Activity	Meal	Transport	Cost
Morning	Train to Lucerne, Chapel Bridge	Hotel buffet (incl.)	Rail FREE	\$0
Afternoon	Boat cruise FREE, opt. Mt. Pilatus 50%	Lunch Lucerne/boat	Boat FREE	\$50
Evening	Lakefront walk, train back	Dinner Lucerne/Zurich	Rail FREE	\$0

Day 20 - Rhine Falls

Time	Activity	Meal	Transport	Cost
Morning	Train to Schaffhausen, Rhine Falls walk	Hotel buffet (incl.)	Rail FREE	\$0
Afternoon	Boat to rock in falls, riverside walk	Rhine Falls restaurant	Boat	\$25
Evening	Return to Zurich, farewell dinner	Special farewell dinner	Rail FREE	\$0

Day 21 - Departure Day

Time	Activity	Meal	Transport	Cost
Morning	Leisure morning, final lake walk, pack	Hotel buffet (incl.)	Walking	\$0
Afternoon	Train to airport FREE, flight to Toronto 9h	Airport lunch	Rail FREE	\$0
Evening	In-flight / Arrive Toronto	Airline meal	Flight	\$0

Nature Highlights by Country

Portugal - Coastal Focus

- Cabo da Roca - Dramatic cliffs, westernmost point of continental Europe
- Praia da Ursa - Wild beach with massive rock formations
- Praia do Guincho - Windswept dunes, popular surfing beach
- Arrabida Natural Park - Mediterranean forest, pristine beaches, crystal water
- Douro River in Porto - UNESCO waterfront, bridge views
- Atlantic Coastline - Matosinhos beach, Foz do Douro district

Spain - Coastal + Mountain

- Costa Brava - Hidden coves, crystal water, fishing villages
- Montserrat - Dramatic rock formations, hiking trails, panoramic views
- Mount Tibidabo - 512m summit, 360-degree Barcelona/sea/Pyrenees views
- Sitges & Barceloneta - Classic Mediterranean beaches
- Girona's Onyar River - Colorful riverside houses

Switzerland - Alpine Focus

- Lauterbrunnen Valley - 72 waterfalls, alpine meadows, Staubbach Falls
- Trummelbach Falls - Glacial waterfalls inside a mountain
- Grindelwald First - Eiger/Monch/Jungfrau views, Lake Bachalpsee, Cliff Walk
- Lake Lucerne - Boat cruises with mountain backdrop
- Rhine Falls - Europe's largest waterfall, boat to central rock
- Lake Zurich - Swimming, boat cruises, lakeside parks

Key Train Information

Portugal

- Lisbon > Sintra: 40 min from Rossio Station (€2.30)
- Lisbon > Cascais: 40 min from Cais do Sodre (€2.30)
- Lisbon > Porto: 3h Alfa Pendular from Santa Apolonia (€27-34)
- Tip: Buy Lisboa Viva card for local transit

Spain

- Barcelona > Blanes (Costa Brava): 1h 20m, Rodalies R1 (~€5)
- Barcelona > Sitges: 35 min, Rodalies R2 (~€4)
- Barcelona > Girona: 40 min, AVE high-speed (~€12)
- Barcelona > Montserrat: 1h 15m, FGC + rack railway (~€25 RT)
- Tip: Buy T-Casual card (10 trips) for Barcelona metro/trains

Switzerland (ALL covered by Swiss Travel Pass)

- Zurich > Lauterbrunnen: 2.5h (change Interlaken) - FREE
- Zurich > Grindelwald: 2.5h (change Interlaken) - FREE

- Zurich > Lucerne: 45 min direct - FREE
- Zurich > Schaffhausen (Rhine Falls): 40 min direct - FREE
- Zurich HB > Zurich Airport: 10 min direct - FREE

What Still Needs Planning / Booking

- Book flights (2-3 months before September 2025)
- Book hotels (2-3 months ahead for September shoulder season)
- Purchase Swiss Travel Pass ([swisstravelsystem.com](https://www.swisstravelsystem.com) or Zurich HB station)
- Reserve specific restaurants if desired
- Book rental car/taxi for Arrabida Natural Park (Day 4)
- Confirm train schedules closer to travel dates
- Create packing list (beach gear + hiking gear + layers for Switzerland)
- Set up Google Maps saved locations for each destination
- Research travel insurance options
- Create rain-day backup plans for outdoor activities

Grocery Stores by City

City	Stores (Best Value First)
Lisbon	Pingo Doce (most popular), Continente, Minipreco (budget)
Porto	Pingo Doce, Continente
Barcelona	Mercadona (best value), Bon Preu, Carrefour Express
Zurich	Migros (BEST VALUE), Coop, Denner (discount), Aldi (budget)

Tip: Use hotel kitchenettes (especially Barcelona's Aparthotel Arai) to prepare breakfasts and snacks. This is especially important in Switzerland where eating out is 2-3x more expensive than Portugal or Spain.